



Keith
Speaking
Academy

COMPLEX SENTENCES

FOR IELTS SPEAKING



KEITH O'HARE



Helping you Become a Confident English Speaker



Many IELTS students lack confidence in their speaking skills.

The Keith Speaking Academy helps you develop your speaking skills so you can face the examiner with confidence and ace the IELTS test.

This PDF is one of many that Keith has developed to help you do this.

Keith has been working in international education for over 20 years as a teacher, teacher trainer, and education manager.

He has helped over 40,000 students prepare for their IELTS Speaking test with his online courses.

Introduction

How do you create complex sentences in [IELTS Speaking](#)?

You probably know that a wide range of grammatical structures is really important if you want to get a band 7 or above in IELTS Speaking.

We can see the band descriptors for Grammar in IELTS Speaking talk about Simple and Complex Structures.

What's more, they say a band 7 student 'uses a range of complex structures with some flexibility'

What you may not sure about is what 'complex grammar' is exactly?
And how do we use it?

That's what we are going to find in this PDF.

Simple and complex tenses

Complex grammar can include many things, but in this lesson, I am going to look at 2 main areas, to give you a flavour of what it can include.

SIMPLE TENSES

Let's look first at tenses. The following are generally seen as **simple tenses**

Present Simple (facts, regular activities)

- I work from home
- I play football every Thursday

Present Continuous (activity now)

- I am drinking tea now

Past Simple (activity finished in past)

- I went to the park yesterday

Past Continuous

- I was reading a book when the phone rang

Future Simple (decisions, predictions, promises)

- I will call you tomorrow
- Tom won't come, he hates parties

COMLEX TENSES

Present Perfect (unfinished past activity, experiences)

- I have lived here for 10 years
- I have never seen the Queen

Present Perfect Continuous (unfinished past activity)

- I have been living here for 10 years

Past Perfect (clarifying an event before moment in past)

- I had already booked the tickets before I arrived at the station

Past Perfect Continuous (continuous activity before moment in past)

- I went to see the doctor because I had been having knee pains

2nd Conditional (unreal situation)

- If I had more money, I would buy a bigger house

3rd Conditional (unreal past situation)

- If I had known, I would have gone

Complex tenses in reported speech

Another example of complex grammar is when we use some of the above tenses in reported speech.

Imagine something happened to you and you are telling the story of that event in IELTS Speaking Part 2.

For example, someone says,

- **“I enjoyed the food but I won’t go back to that restaurant”**

When telling the story in [Part 2](#), you should use reported speech, and then the above becomes,

- **“He said he had enjoyed the food, but that he wouldn’t go to that restaurant again.”**

However, complexity doesn't lie just in one tense.

It lies across whole sentences and whole answers.

To see how this works, let’s look next at the simple secret to building complex structures – that is “Clauses”

Clauses and complex sentences

You probably know about ‘sentences’, as these are the basic building blocks of writing.

But we don’t always speak in sentences.

Really, it’s true!

Take this example of a written sentence about the city where I live,

I visited Santander which is not a very pretty city due to a fire that destroyed it in 1941.

When we speak we tend to break our speech into smaller units that are easier to use and remember. These smaller units of speech are called **clauses**.

The above in spoken English would look like this,

- “I visited Santander
- It’s not a very pretty city
- Because there was a fire
- A fire that destroyed it in 1941”

A clause is the basic building block of speaking. This is the secret to building complex sentences in IELTS Speaking.

All you have to do is put the blocks together and build!



What is a clause?

A clause usually has a **subject** (sometimes called a noun phrase) and a **verb phrase** (sometimes called a predicate) that tells us about the subject.

For example,

- I live in Spain

I (subject) + live in Spain (verb phrase)

We can build complex structures by building 2, 3 or more clauses.

The thing is in order to build complex sentences in IELTS Speaking, don't focus on perfect writing and punctuation. Instead, focus on building up clauses, using perfect pauses and intonation patterns.

How do we do that?

Let me show you some very specific examples, so it's crystal clear.

Clauses and conjunctions

First of all, let's take examples of joining clauses with conjunctions, these include:

- and
- but
- for
- nor
- or
- so

		and		
		but		
		for		
Clause 1	+	nor		+ Clause 2
		or		
		So		

For example, we can say,

- I live in Spain
- **and** I like it very much,
- **but** the weather is a bit too hot.

Relative clauses

Next, let's take examples of **describing** a clause with adjective clauses or relative clauses. In this case, we would use words like

- who
- which
- that
- where
- when
- whose

	who	
	which	
	that	
Clause 1	+	where
		when
		whose
		+ Clause 2

For example, we can say,

- I live in Spain **which is a beautiful country**
- I live in a city **where there is not too much traffic**
- I work for a woman **who is very friendly**

Now you can see how we can start to build blocks. Here are some more examples, as we build more complex sentences.

- I live in Spain
 - **which is a pretty big country**
 - and I like it very much.
-
- I live in Spain,
 - **which is a pretty big country,**
 - and I like it very much,
 - **although the weather is a bit too hot.**

Adverbial clauses

Finally, let's look at describing how, when or why something happens with adverbial clauses. In these cases, we would use words like

- because
- although
- when
- if
- until
- as if
- before
- after

Clause 1	+	before	+ Clause 2
		after	
		because	
		although	
		when	
		if	
		until	
		as if	

For example, we can say,

- I decided to buy a playstation **after seeing an advert on TV**
- I lived in Malaysia **before moving to Spain**
- I live in Spain **because the food is great**

Again, you can now you can see how we can start to build more complex sentences in IELTS Speaking.

- I live in Spain
 - **because** the food is great,
 - **although** I think they eat too much fish
-
- I work as a teacher
 - **because** I love showing people new things,
 - **although** I do find the long hours are tiring
-
- I live in Spain,
 - **which is a pretty big country,**
 - because the food is great.
-
- I live in Spain,
 - **which** is a pretty big country,
 - **because** the food is great,
 - **although** I think they eat too much fish.

In this last example, you can see how we can notably build up many clauses, we can also use more complex tenses in these clauses.

- I have been living in Spain for 10 years,
- **which is quite a long time actually**
- partly because the food is great,
- **although** I think they eat too much fish.

All of this helps create more complex sentences in your IELTS Speaking, and so helping you get a band 7 or above.

The key, is to practice. So, now go back and practice making some complex phrases to describe you, your job, your family or your home.

Think about mixing different tenses in your clauses

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